

Functionalism

'Form follows function' generated the modernist approach of functionalism, even though functionalism can be argued to have been around since ancient times. It dictates that the form of a building be determined by its purpose, materials and structure, rather than by the aesthetic principles of an architect's designs. The rise of functionalism was spurred in part by rapid social and economic growth in America, which called for larger buildings. The new mass-production of steel led to skyscrapers with lightweight skeletons on which the rest of the building's elements – including, significantly, walls – were suspended. This column-and-frame construction allowed taller buildings with larger windows, which created lighter interiors. Many functionalist buildings were based on the three-part composition of a classical column: base, shaft and cornice. Successful functionalist buildings include the glass and steel AEG turbine factory in Berlin (1907–10), designed by Peter Behrens and New York's triangular 22-storey Flatiron Building (1902, opposite), by Daniel Hudson Burnham.

